The Lost Child

The big idea

Mulk Raj Anand's short story follows a little boy at a **spring festival fair**. He wants every toy and sweet he sees, but when he gets lost, none of them matter any more: he only wants his **mother and father**. The story shows a child's psychology and the truth that **parents' love is more precious than anything**.

Summary

1. On a bright spring day the boy goes to the fair with his parents. On the way he lags behind to look at **toys in shops**. He asks for them but his father's red-eyed stare makes him move on.
2. He passes a **mustard field**, chases **dragon-flies** and **butterflies**, and sees insects and worms. His mother calls him; he picks up fallen **petals** of flowers.
3. At the fair, he sees a **sweetmeat seller** with **burfi** (his favourite), a **flower-seller** with **garlands of gulmohur**, a **balloon-seller**, a **snake-charmer** playing the pungi, and a **roundabout** (merry-go-round). Each time he wants something but stays silent, knowing his parents will refuse, or his father will say he is greedy.
4. Near the roundabout he turns and finds his parents are gone. He panics, runs here and there crying "Mother, Father", and is caught in a frantic crowd at a **shrine**.
5. A **kind man** lifts him onto his shoulders and tries to comfort him. He takes him to the roundabout, offers balloons, flowers, sweets and a ride, but the boy refuses everything, sobbing, **"I want my mother, I want my father!"**

TURNING POINT

Before he is lost, the child wants everything. After he is lost, he wants nothing but his parents. Things lose their charm without the sense of security parents give.

Characters

- **The child**: curious, playful, easily attracted; obedient (does not insist), and deeply attached to his parents.
- **The parents**: loving but firm; they say no to toys and sweets.
- **The kind stranger**: compassionate, tries everything to calm the child.

Themes

- **Parental love and security**.
- **Child psychology**: desires change with circumstances.
- Contrast of the joyful fair and the child's loneliness in a crowd.

THE CHILD IS NEVER FOUND IN THE STORY

The story ends with the stranger trying to comfort him. Do not write that his parents came back; the ending is left open.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What things attracted the child at the fair? Why did he move on without asking? Why did he refuse the stranger's offers? What does the story teach? Value points: burfi, garland, balloons, snake charmer, roundabout; "I want my mother, I want my father".

Quick recap

- Child wants toys and sweets but does not insist.

- Gets lost near the roundabout/shrine crowd.
- Refuses all offers; only wants his parents.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "The Lost Child"?
   (a) Mulk Raj Anand (b) Ruskin Bond (c) R. K. Laxman (d) Premchand
2. Which sweet did the child love?
   (a) Jalebi (b) Gulab jamun (c) Laddoo (d) Burfi
3. Why did the child not insist on buying the things he wanted?
   (a) He had his own money (b) He knew his parents would refuse or call him greedy (c) He did not really like them (d) The sellers were rude
4. What kind of flowers did the flower seller have?
   (a) Roses (b) Gulmohur (c) Marigold (d) Jasmine
5. When the kind man offered him toys and sweets, the child
   (a) took the balloons happily (b) asked for burfi (c) refused and cried for his parents (d) ran away from him
6. What is the central theme of the story?
   (a) Fun at fairs (b) The dangers of crowds (c) Greed of children (d) The importance of parents' love and security
7. Why did the lost child refuse the things offered by the stranger?

Answers: 1. a 2. d 3. b 4. b 5. c 6. d 7. see notes